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Modern Noir Expansion

Łargetshape For Fate’s Edge Tabletop RPG

Łarge**Urban Shadows and Moral Ambiguity Framework**

Łarge Designed for Cases of Any Length

Łarge Complete with Investigation Generator System

Łarge **Featuring Vice Timer Character System**

52Card Case Generation

Investigation Point Economy

Modular Urban Environment Mechanics

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1 Modern Noir Expansion Overview

1.1 Core Concept

Noir in Fate's Edge should create moral ambiguity and personal consequences while maintaining player agency through meaningful investigation and social choices. The city is both setting and character.

1.2 Key Innovations

tem Vice Timer system for character flaws tem 52card case generator for quick setup
 tem Investigation point economy for resource management tem Evidence rating system for clue tracking tem Districtbased environmental modifiers

1.3 Target Themes

tem Moral ambiguity and ethical compromises tem Urban isolation and personal stakes
 tem Information as currency and power tem Atmospheric tension and city as character tem Personal consequences and character growth tem Social dynamics and class conflict

1.4 Mechanical Focus

tem Investigation procedures with resource costs tem Social manipulation and information gathering tem Character corruption through Vice system tem Environmental hazards and urban modifiers tem Evidence management and case building

2 Core Mechanical Framework

2.1 Vice Timer Character Flaw Management

The signature system represents the noir protagonist's fatal flaw through a mechanical system that creates tension between character growth and selfdestruction.

Purpose and Integration This system connects to the existing Boon economy while adding personal consequences that drive narrative forward. Players choose when to spend Boons to prevent Vice advancement, creating meaningful decisions about selfcontrol versus indulgence.

Sample Uses:

tem Emotional Vice temptation during key interview (+1 segment) player spends 1 Boon to resist tem Physical Vice crisis state affects investigation rolls (2 dice) player must spend 2 Boons to clear 1 segment tem Professional Vice creates complications with authorities party must collectively decide how to manage compromised colleague

2.2 Resource Management Investigation Points and Evidence

Acquisition Methods:

tem Case setup (2 base points per case) tem Successful investigation rolls (1 point per success) tem Diamond card rewards from case resolution tem XP conversion (2 Boons = 1 XP, max 2 per session)

Spending Options:

tem Automatic success on investigation actions (1 point per use) tem Evidence preservation and enhancement tem Information brokerage with contacts tem Emergency rerolls in critical situations

Narrative Weight: Players must choose between immediate investigative advantages and longterm case building.

2.3 Risk/Reward Balance

Safe Choices:

tem Surfacelevel investigation with minimal personal exposure tem Conservative approach with reduced Investigation Point economy (1 die penalties) tem Avoiding direct confrontation with dangerous elements

Controlled Choices:

tem Deep investigation with significant personal cost tem Direct engagement with criminal elements tem Pursuing sensitive information at personal risk tem +12 Vice segments, evidence contamination risks

Failure States:

tem Case collapse due to evidence loss or witness intimidation tem Personal reputation damage affecting future cases tem Legal consequences requiring character retirement tem Character transformation into antagonist

3 Campaign Timer Framework

3.1 Primary Timer : Case Timer (410 segments)

Progress toward case resolution and complications affecting investigation timeline.

line Case Timer	Progress toward case resolution and complications
line Segments	●●●●0/4 (for 25 cards)
line	

Advancement Triggers:

tem Time pressure elements (25 cards): +1 segment per day/scene tem Complication cards (610): +1 segment tem Major complications (J/Q/K): +2 segments tem Twists/Aces: +3 segments or immediate crisis

Consequences when filled: Case reaches critical point resolution required, evidence destroyed, witness lost, or personal crisis.

3.2 Secondary Timers

sectionVice Timer (4 segments per vice)

Character personal flaw progression affecting performance and judgment.

line Vice Timer	Character personal flaw progression
line Segments	●●●●0/4
line	

Triggers:

tem Temptation situations: +1 segment per scene (automatic) tem Resisted advancement with 1 Boon tem Cleared with 2 Boons (1 segment reduction)

Consequences: Increasing penalties to rolls, SB generation, crisis states requiring immediate attention.

sectionPressure Timer (68 segments)

External forces complicating investigation through authority/criminal interference.

line Pressure Timer	External forces complicating investigation
line Segments	●●●●●●0/6
line	

Triggers:

tem Authority interference: +1 segment tem Media attention: +1 segment tem Criminal retaliation: +2 segments tem Personal threats: +2 segments

Consequences: Reduced investigation options, increased danger, forced resolution paths.

sectionReputation Timer (8 segments)

Professional/social standing effects on future opportunities and contact cooperation.

line Reputation Timer	Professional/social standing effects
line Segments	●●●●●●●●0/8

| line |

Triggers:

tem Ethical compromises: +1 segment tem Successful cases: +1 segment tem Public exposure: +2 segments tem Scandals: +3 segments

Consequences: Future case difficulty, contact availability, authority cooperation levels.

3.3 Timer Interaction

Case Timer drives other timers; as it advances, Pressure and Reputation timers accelerate. High Vice segments make Case advancement faster due to compromised judgment.

4 Character Integration System

4.1 Thematic Character Options

section Professional Archetypes

Private Investigator:

tem +1 Investigation, +1 Subterfuge tem Access to information networks and contacts tem Vulnerable to authority interference and legal complications

Rogue Cop:

tem +1 Command, +1 Intimidation tem Authority cooperation bonus but complications with criminal elements tem Vulnerable to internal affairs investigations

Street Samurai:

tem +1 Melee/Brawl, +1 Stealth tem Combat training and discipline but 1 social rolls due to reputation tem Vulnerable to legal consequences and authority attention

Socialite:

tem +1 Presence, +1 Insight tem Access to high society information and resources tem Vulnerable to blackmail and family scandals

Hacker:

tem +1 Technology, +1 Investigation (digital) tem Access to digital information and surveillance systems tem Vulnerable to physical confrontations and legal consequences

4.2 Background Integration

Criminal Past:

tem Start with 1 Vice segment tem Gain +1 die to intimidation/social manipulation
tem Vulnerable to law enforcement attention and blackmail

Police Connections:

tem Authority cooperation bonus (+1 die) tem Creates complications with criminal elements
tem Vulnerable to internal investigations and ethical conflicts

Wealthy Family:

tem Resources and contacts (+1 Investigation Point base) tem Vulnerable to family scandals and expectations
tem May attract unwanted attention from criminals

Military Veteran:

tem Combat training and discipline (+1 Melee/Brawl) tem PTSD triggers and trust issues (Psychological Vice risk)
tem May have valuable insider knowledge but legal restrictions

5 Magic Users in Modern Noir

labelsec:ritesusersnoir

In the Noir frame, every magic user is an operator caught in the web of Patronal capital. Their methods and relationships define not only what powers they wield, but how they fit into the Patron's strategy. Below are archetypes with recommendations for Patrons whose "brand" best suits the role. Magic is considered fictional by most people in the world and they often rationalize any effect they see.

Cantors The Viral Prophets

Cantors drift through smokefilled bars, subways, and alleys, weaving Low Rites into streetlevel songs and whispers. Their performances aren't just magic, but **memetic advertising** for a Patron's domain.

tem **Role:** Street prophets, viral influencers, underground DJs. tem **Strengths:** Low barrier of entry; visible, contagious influence. tem **Risks:** Every note spreads corruption; Patrons watch Cantors as trial runs for recruitment. tem **Recommended Patrons:**tem **Ikasha (Shadow)** whispers of secrets in every back alley. tem **Malachai (Curses)** corruption through intimate nightlife scenes. tem **Inaea (Pleasure)** viral revels in clubs, addiction to comfort. tem **The Sealed Gate** lockstep beats that spread compulsions to seal or reveal.

Runekeepers The Loyal Operatives

Runekeepers are the career staff: lawyers, lobbyists, priests in designer suits. They carry codices and contracts instead of hymnals. Their rites are the **internal policies** of the Patronal corporation.

tem **Role:** Corporate agents, occult lawyers, syndicate priests. tem **Strengths:** Access to Standard and High Rites, stable longterm power. tem **Risks:** Debt to the Patron escalates like compounding interest. tem **Recommended Patrons:**tem **The Gallow's Bell** judges, auditors, and enforcers of cosmic justice. tem **The Clockwork Monad** efficiency consultants and transhumanists. tem **Maelstraeus** dealmakers, brokers, and infernal financiers. tem **Ikasha** intelligence networks and shadow brokerages.

Invokers The Contractors

Invokers are freelancers who crack seals like they're opening vaults. They bring highrisk power to bear on short contracts, with no promise of loyalty after the invoice clears.

tem **Role:** Mercenary specialists, hackers, saboteurs. tem **Strengths:** Potent, immediate rites; adaptable to client needs. tem **Risks:** Fragile loyalty, heavy Obligation, prone to burnout. tem **Recommended Patrons:**tem **Malachai** oneoff curses for payback jobs. tem **Raéyn** sea or portlinked sabotage, smuggling networks. tem **The CarrionKing** hit jobs, cleanups, and coverups. tem **The Clockwork Monad** precision engineering or data heists.

Summoners The Fixers

Summoners are managers of Patronal assets. They call in ephemeral muscle, otherworldly assistants, or ephemeral constructs like a manager booking temps for a job.

tem **Role:** Crime bosses, syndicate fixers, occult talent agents. tem **Strengths:** Can field multiple assets simultaneously; tactical flexibility. tem **Risks:** Dependence on summoned assets; if denied, they stand exposed. tem **Recommended Patrons:**tem **The Sealed Gate** summoning lockedaway entities. tem **The CarrionKing** corpselike enforcers, rotborne allies. tem **Inaea** alluring familiars who offer distraction and indulgence.

Casters / Free Casters The Innovators

Casters design their own spells from first principles, like startups prototyping dangerous new products. They exploit the "tags" of Patrons as raw APIs to invent something original.

tem **Role:** Occult RD labs, backroom innovators, blackmarket inventors. tem **Strengths:** Flexibility, creativity, disruptive potential. tem **Risks:** Unstable

results; prone to backlash and collapse. tem **Recommended Patrons:**tem **The Clockwork Monad** iterative perfection and modular design. tem **Maelstraeus** innovation framed as deals with dangerous fine print. tem **Ikasha** knowledge as exploitable data.

[colback=black!2,colframe=black!40!white,title=Noir Table Stakes] In Modern Noir, every Rites user is more than a spellcaster: they are a participant in a Patron’s market strategy. Cantors spread the brand, Runekeepers maintain the infrastructure, Invokers deliver mercenary results, Summoners manage assets, and Casters innovate risky new tech. Together, they keep the city humming with corruption.

5.1 Mechanical Hooks

sectionVice Management

Each character starts with 14 Vice segments based on card draw:

tem Jack Draw: 1 segment tem Queen Draw: 2 segments tem King Draw: 3 segments
tem Ace Draw: 4 segments (immediate crisis scene)

sectionInvestigation Specialties

Characters can become experts in specific investigation types:

tem Surveillance Specialist: +1 die to Stealthbased investigation tem Interrogation Expert: +1 die to Insightbased social rolls tem Evidence Analyst: +1 die to Perceptionbased scene examination tem Digital Investigator: +1 die to Technologybased research tem Street Network: +1 die to Subterfugebased infiltration

sectionReputation Modifiers

Professional standing affects case difficulty and contact availability:

tem 02 segments: +1 die to investigation (respected professional) tem 35 segments: Standard investigation (mixed reputation) tem 68 segments: 1 die to investigation (questionable methods)

sectionEvidence Handling

Character skills affect evidence quality and preservation:

tem Investigation 3+: Can improve evidence ratings by one grade tem Technology 3+: Digital evidence preservation bonus tem Perception 3+: Hidden evidence detection bonus

6 Quick Setup Protocol

6.1 30Minute Campaign Launch

Character Preparation:

- tem Use pregenerated characters or build using 2032 XP with noir-themed backgrounds
- tem Ensure party has mix of investigation, combat, and social capabilities
- tem Assign relevant Talents for noir engagement (Streetwise, Hardened, Smooth Talker)

Core Conflict Establishment:

- tem Draw 3 cards (Spade=Crime, Heart=Person, Club=Complication) to establish case
- tem Identify highest rank for Case Timer size (25:4, 610:6, J/Q/K:8, A:10)
- tem Draw 1 Diamond for potential reward/motivation

Opening Scene Hook:

- tem Immediate investigation opportunity with personal connection
- tem Time pressure element creating urgency
- tem Introduction to key NPC from Heart card
- tem First complication from Club card manifestation

Primary Campaign Timer :

- tem Case Timer based on highest card rank
- tem Each character draws Vice card for starting segments
- tem Start with 2 Investigation Points for immediate use

Key Mechanical Tutorial:

- tem Introduce Investigation Points through first investigation scene
- tem Demonstrate Vice Timer management through temptation scenario
- tem Show evidence rating system through clue discovery
- tem Establish district modifiers through environmental description

6.2 Scaling Options

sectionOneShot (12 sessions)

- tem Single Case Timer with simplified complications
- tem 12 Vices per character for focused character development
- tem Simplified evidence system with basic AF ratings
- tem Resolution focused on immediate case outcome

sectionShort Campaign (35 sessions)

- tem Full Vice system with multiple potential vices
- tem Reputation/Pressure timers creating ongoing consequences
- tem Evidence degradation system with daily tracking
- tem Interconnected cases with sequel hooks

sectionExtended Campaign (6+ sessions)

- tem Multiple interconnected cases affecting city/region
- tem Character retirement/promotion

options for broken PCs tem Permanent reputation effects influencing all future cases
tem Citywide consequences from major case resolutions

7 Environmental and Narrative Mechanics

7.1 SettingDriven Mechanics

sectionDistrict Modifiers

Different city areas provide investigation bonuses/penalties:

Downtown/Core Business District:

tem Investigation: +1 Research, 1 Surveillance tem Social: +1 Interview (professional), 1 Infiltration tem Hazards: Security cameras, private security, high visibility

Waterfront/Docks:

tem Investigation: +1 Surveillance, 1 Interview tem Social: +1 Intimidation, 2 Sway
tem Hazards: Criminal presence, unsafe structures, limited lighting

Residential/Suburbs:

tem Investigation: +1 Interview, 1 Infiltration tem Social: +1 Building Rapport, +1 Research (public records) tem Hazards: Nosy neighbors, home security, limited escape routes

Entertainment District:

tem Investigation: +1 Infiltration, 1 Surveillance tem Social: +1 Social Engineering, 1 Direct Confrontation tem Hazards: Crowds, alcohol/drugs, transient population

Industrial/Warehouse:

tem Investigation: +1 Scene Examination, 2 Interview tem Social: +2 Intimidation, 2 Sway tem Hazards: Physical danger, limited escape, noise cover

sectionTime and Weather Effects

Time of Day:

tem **Daylight (6 AM - 6 PM):** +1 Scene Examination, 1 Surveillance tem **Twilight (6 AM/6 PM - 8 AM/8 PM):** Balanced conditions tem **Night (8 PM - 6 AM):** +1 Surveillance, 1 Interview

Weather Conditions:

tem **Clear:** Standard conditions tem **Rain:** +1 Surveillance (fewer witnesses), 1 Scene Examination tem **Fog/Heavy Rain:** +2 Infiltration, 2 Interview tem **Snow:** +1 Tracking, 1 Chase Scenes

7.2 Atmosphere Tools

sectionUrban Sensory Engagement

Sound:

tem Traffic, sirens, whispered conversations tem Neon hum, footsteps in alleyways
tem Jazz from clubs, arguments from apartments tem Surveillance equipment, construction noise

Sight:

tem Neon reflections on wet pavement tem Shadow play between buildings tem
Surveillance cameras on every corner tem Contrast between wealth and poverty districts

Smell:

tem Coffee shops and diners tem Cigarettes and alcohol tem Rain on concrete and industrial chemicals tem Expensive perfumes vs. urban decay odors

Touch:

tem Rough brick walls and fire escapes tem Polished lobby surfaces vs. grimy streets
tem Cold metal of fire escapes and fences tem Expensive fabrics vs. worn clothing textures

Taste:

tem Cheap diner coffee and pie tem Expensive restaurant food and wine tem Street vendor hot dogs and pretzels tem Cigarettes, alcohol, urban air quality

7.3 Narrative Structure

sectionScene Types

Investigation:

tem Gathering clues, evidence collection, research tem Wits + Investigation or related skills with Investigation Point costs tem May generate SB for complications or Vice temptations

Social Encounter:

tem Interviews, interrogations, negotiations tem Presence + Insight/Sway with position modifiers tem Vice Timer advancement opportunities for relevant characters

Action Sequence:

tem Chases, combat, breakins tem Standard Fate's Edge combat with urban envi-

ronmental modifiers tem May trigger Pressure Timer advancement or Reputation changes

Moral Choice:

tem Ethical dilemmas, compromise decisions, personal cost evaluations tem May trigger Vice Timer advancement or Reputation Timer changes tem Creates sequel hooks or character development opportunities

sectionPacing Markers

Sessions 1:

tem Case introduction with immediate hook tem Initial investigation establishing methods tem First complications and NPC introductions tem Vice temptation opportunities for character establishment

Sessions 23:

tem Pattern recognition revealing deeper conspiracy tem Key revelations connecting case elements tem Major complications testing investigation progress tem Character development through Vice management

Sessions 4+:

tem Climax with multiple resolution paths tem Consequences of previous choices becoming clear tem Character retirement/promotion opportunities tem Setup for sequel cases or campaign conclusion

sectionResolution Formats

Success States:

tem **The Professional:** Clean case resolution with minimal ethical compromise (1215 XP) tem **The Reformed:** Case solved through moral growth and ethical choices (1518 XP) tem **The Pragmatist:** Effective resolution through necessary compromises (1013 XP)

Failure States:

tem **The Fallen:** Case resolution through corruption and ethical abandonment (810 XP, character change) tem **The Broken:** Personal/case failure leading to character retirement (58 XP) tem **The Framed:** Success achieved but at cost of personal freedom/reputation (1012 XP, ongoing complications)

Partial Success:

tem **The Compromise:** Partial resolution with significant ongoing issues (1215 XP) tem **The Sacrifice:** Success achieved through personal loss or ethical compromise (1316 XP)

Pyrrhic Victory:

tem **The Cost:** Complete success with devastating personal/professional consequences (1518 XP, major changes)

8 GM Toolkit

8.1 Session Preparation Checklist

tem Draw case cards and establish Case Timer	tem Prepare key NPCs with motivations and secrets
tem Plan 23 investigation scenes with different approach options	tem Identify Vice temptation opportunities
tem Prepare environmental complications (1 SB each)	tem Set up resolution paths with different consequences
tem Prepare sensory descriptions for atmosphere building	

8.2 Complication Generator

sectionMild (1 SB)

tem Key witness disappears before interview tem Evidence contaminated or destroyed
 tem Surveillance detected by subject tem Unexpected phone call interrupts investigation
 tem Power outage in investigation area

sectionModerate (2 SB)

tem Media attention escalates case profile tem Police obstruction or investigation begins
 tem Technology fails during critical moment tem Informant goes silent or changes story
 tem Traffic accident blocks access routes

sectionSerious (3 SB)

tem Crime scene compromised by unauthorized personnel tem New suspect emerges with solid alibi for original suspect
 tem Evidence chain of custody broken tem Personal connection to case compromised
 tem Authority figures demand case details

sectionMajor (4+ SB)

tem Alibi checks out completely, eliminating primary suspect tem Personal relationship compromised through blackmail
 tem Authority investigation begins into investigator conduct tem Key evidence revealed to be planted or fabricated
 tem Innocent person implicated requiring case restart

8.3 Player Agency Reminders

Handling Unexpected Approaches:

tem Embrace creativity but maintain noir consequences tem Adapt investigation paths

to player innovations tem Allow success but with appropriate complications tem Provide multiple valid paths to objectives

When to Push Back:

tem Only when player choices would break core noir themes tem When actions would eliminate all tension or challenge tem When safety/pacing requires narrative redirection tem When mechanical balance needs preservation

Maintaining Tension:

tem Use timer advancement and Vice temptations rather than adversarial GMing tem Provide meaningful choices with real consequences tem Balance hope and despair throughout campaign tem Let player decisions drive case complications

9 Experience and Resolution Systems

9.1 Experience Awards

Participation:

tem +2 XP per session attendance tem +1 XP for meaningful noir engagement tem +1 XP for contributing to atmospheric tension

Thematic Play:

tem +12 XP for meaningful noir engagement tem +1 XP for playing character's vices appropriately tem +2 XP for embracing moral ambiguity consequences

Risk Taking:

tem +13 XP for choosing dangerous investigative paths tem +2 XP for resisting Vice temptations at cost tem +1 XP for pursuing sensitive information

Vice Management:

tem +12 XP for successfully managing character flaws tem +1 XP for partial Vice resistance with consequences tem +3 XP for transforming Vice into character growth

Narrative Contribution:

tem +12 XP for creating memorable noir moments tem +1 XP for contributing to group investigation success tem +2 XP for defining campaign's central noir theme

10 Modular Design Elements

10.1 PlugandPlay Components

Vice Timer System:

- tem Works independently in any characterdriven campaign
- tem Scalable segment counts for different campaign lengths
- tem Compatible with existing Boon economy

Investigation Procedures:

- tem Enhance any mystery/investigation scenario
- tem Modular action types with different skill requirements
- tem Integration with resource management systems

Evidence Rating System:

- tem Adds depth to clue management in any investigation
- tem Scalable complexity from simple AF to detailed tracking
- tem Creates meaningful choices about evidence preservation

District Modifiers:

- tem Can enhance any urban setting
- tem Modular effects based on campaign tone
- tem Compatible with existing environmental hazards

10.2 CrossExpansion Compatibility

Horror Expansion:

- tem Psychological breaking points enhance moral ambiguity
- tem Investigation procedures complement horror clue gathering
- tem Urban atmosphere supports noir horror settings

Cyberpunk Expansion:

- tem Corporate conspiracy elements in case backgrounds
- tem Technology investigation skills enhance digital forensics
- tem Character corruption parallels cybernetic augmentation

Fantasy Expansion:

- tem Urban political intrigue mirrors noir social dynamics
- tem Investigation procedures work with magical clues
- tem Character vices enhance moral complexity in fantasy

10.3 Power Scaling

Lower Tiers (Rookie/Seasoned):

- tem Reduced Vice penalties and simpler crisis states
- tem More Investigation Points for easier case progression
- tem Fewer environmental complications and modifiers
- tem More recovery options for timer advancement

Higher Tiers (Veteran/Paragon):

- tem Increased corruption risks and severe Vice consequences
- tem Complex moral

choices with no clear right answers tem Harsher environmental modifiers and complications tem Permanent consequences for filled timers and broken characters

New Players:

tem Streamlined systems with fewer timers tem Clearer resolution paths and guidance tem Reduced penalties for high Vice states tem More safety mechanisms and recovery options

Experienced Players:

tem Additional complications and harsher consequences tem Fewer safety mechanisms and more permanent effects tem Integration with existing campaign threads and consequences tem Character retirement/promotion options for extreme states

11 Quick Reference Appendix

11.1 Investigation Actions

Core Actions (Use Fate's Edge dice pool):

tem **Surveillance:** Wits + Stealth (DV 24) tem **Interview:** Presence + Insight (DV 13) tem **Research:** Wits + Investigation (DV 23) tem **Scene Exam:** Wits + Perception (DV 14) tem **Infiltration:** Wits + Subterfuge (DV 34)

Position Effects:

tem **Dominant:** You act from safety or advantage. Failure still leaves you options. tem **Controlled:** Standard case. Failure has teeth, but not ruin. tem **Desperate:** High stakes. Failure is severe; success may bring extra XP.

Investigation Points: Spend 1 to automatically succeed on any action (once per scene)

11.2 Vice Timer Quick Reference

Vice Timer Management:

tem **1 Boon:** Prevent Vice Timer from incrementing this scene tem **2 Boons:** Clear 1 segment from Vice Timer tem **4 Segments Full:** Draw new Vice card, apply fallout, reset timer

Vice Timer Penalties:

tem **1 Segment:** +1 SB on vicerelated rolls tem **2 Segments:** +2 SB, 1 die to resist vice tem **3 Segments:** +3 SB, 2 dice, 1 Boon per session to function tem **4 Segments:** +4 SB, 3 dice, no Boon spending until resolved

11.3 District Modifiers Quick Reference

Downtown/Core Business District:

tem Investigation: +1 Research, 1 Surveillance tem Social: +1 Interview (professional), 1 Infiltration tem Hazards: Security cameras, private security, high visibility

Waterfront/Docks:

tem Investigation: +1 Surveillance, 1 Interview tem Social: +1 Intimidation, 2 Sway tem Hazards: Criminal presence, unsafe structures, limited lighting

Residential/Suburbs:

tem Investigation: +1 Interview, 1 Infiltration tem Social: +1 Building Rapport, +1 Research (public records) tem Hazards: Nosy neighbors, home security, limited escape routes

Quick Complications (1 SB each):

tem Key witness disappears tem Evidence is contaminated tem Media attention escalates tem Police obstruction tem Surveillance detected tem Informant goes silent tem Crime scene compromised tem New suspect emerges tem Alibi checks out tem Technology fails tem Vice temptation appears tem Personal connection compromised

11.4 Case Timer Setup

Card Rank to Timer Size:

tem **25**: 4 segments (simple case) tem **610**: 6 segments (moderate complexity) tem **J/Q/K**: 8 segments (complex case) tem **A**: 10 segments (twist case)

Evidence Rating System:

tem **A+**: Unimpeachable direct observation, clear documentation tem **A**: Strong solid documentation, reliable witness tem **B**: Good circumstantial but compelling tem **C**: Fair circumstantial, questionable reliability tem **D**: Weak hearsay, speculation tem **F**: Unreliable contradicted, obtained illegally

12 Design Philosophy Requirements

12.1 Must Include Elements

Meaningful Player Choice:

tem Every major decision (investigation approach, ethical choices, risk level) has clear, lasting consequences tem Multiple valid approaches to case obstacles (investigation, combat, social, flight) tem Characterspecific Vice temptations that reflect individual

backgrounds and flaws tem Resolution paths that reward different play styles and thematic choices

Mechanical Theme Integration:

tem Vice Timer system directly serves noir themes of moral ambiguity and selfdestruction tem Investigation Point economy reinforces information currency themes tem Evidence rating system mirrors the fragility of truth in noir tem District modifiers embody the city as character concept

Gradual Complexity:

tem Introduce systems gradually across sessions (Investigation Points Vice Timer Evidence System) tem Start with basic case management before adding secondary timers tem Reveal complex district effects as campaign progresses tem Scale Vice consequences with character development

Multiple Valid Approaches:

tem Investigation, combat, and social solutions all viable with different risk/reward profiles tem Different character archetypes can contribute meaningfully to case resolution tem Multiple resolution paths that reward different campaign approaches tem Adaptive case responses to player innovations

Character Spotlights:

tem Each session provides opportunities for different character types tem Investigation specialists excel with research and surveillance tem Social characters shine during interviews and negotiations tem Combat characters handle action sequences and intimidation

Clear Continuation Hooks:

tem Win or lose, cases create sequel opportunities or ongoing consequences tem Partial timer fills create regional reputation effects tem Character Vice development provides campaign long arcs tem Case resolutions affect future investigation difficulty

12.2 Should Avoid Elements

Railroading:

tem Player choices genuinely matter to case outcomes tem Multiple resolution paths with different consequences tem Varied investigation approaches leading to different revelations tem Adaptive case responses to player innovations

Information Dumps:

tem Lore emerges through investigation and social interaction tem Case details re-

vealed through player actions rather than exposition tem NPC motivations discovered through interviews and observation tem Evidence guides investigation rather than railroading

Mechanical Bloat:

tem New systems enhance rather than complicate core mechanics tem Vice Timer integrates with existing Boon economy tem Investigation procedures use standard resolution with thematic modifiers tem Timer interactions follow logical causeandeffect relationships

Unwinnable States:

tem Even failure leads to interesting continuation tem Partial success provides ongoing character development tem Case collapse creates sequel campaign hooks tem Character transformation offers new adventure possibilities

Generic Elements:

tem Every location, NPC, and encounter serves noir themes tem District modifiers reinforce urban atmosphere concepts tem Vice temptations reflect core noir character flaws tem Case complications embody moral ambiguity themes

12.3 Excellence Indicators

Innovative but Accessible:

tem New mechanics (Vice Timer , Investigation Points) feel natural to noir genre tem Integration with existing Boon economy maintains system familiarity tem Scalable complexity allows for gradual learning curve tem Clear mechanical procedures support narrative noir themes

Thematic Consistency:

tem Every element reinforces core themes (moral ambiguity, urban isolation, information currency) tem Timer names and effects directly relate to noir concepts tem Vice temptations reflect psychological and moral noir themes tem Resolution paths embody different noir story archetypes

Scalable Design:

tem Works for different group sizes and experience levels tem Streamlined timers for new players maintain core tension tem Extended campaign options for experienced groups tem Modular components work independently or together

PrepEfficient:

tem GM can run with minimal preparation using card systems tem Checklist provided

for session preparation tem Index cards suggested for quick reference during play tem Generator systems reduce prep time for new cases

Session Sized Beats:

tem Clear goals and climaxes for each session tem Investigation setup provides session foundation tem Key revelations create midcampaign tension tem Case resolution drives session conclusion

Player Agency Documentation:

tem Clear guidance on handling unexpected choices tem Embrace creativity while maintaining noir elements tem Provide multiple valid approaches to case obstacles tem Maintain tension through consequences rather than adversarial GMing

13 Modern Noir Deck Generators

13.1 Quick Case System

Core Investigation Mechanics

OneShot Case Framework (Designed for 23 hour sessions):

Case Elements (Draw 3 cards from standard deck):

tem **Spade:** Crime/Inciting Incident (the hook that pulls you in) tem **Heart:** Key Person (central figure in the case) tem **Club:** Complication/Pressure (what makes it difficult) tem **Diamond:** Reward/Resolution (what you can gain or achieve)

Rank Interpretation:

tem **25:** Simple case with straightforward resolution tem **610:** Moderate complexity with meaningful choices tem **J/Q/K:** Complex case with multiple viable solutions tem **Ace:** Twist the case is not what it initially seemed

Quick Setup:

tem Draw 3 cards (Spade, Heart, Club) tem Identify the highest rank as your main Challenge Timer (25: 4 segments, 610: 6 segments, J/Q/K: 8 segments, A: 10 segments) tem Start with 2 Investigation Points

Core investigative activities (use Fate's Edge core mechanic):

Surveillance (Wits + Stealth, DV 24):

tem Following suspects without detection tem Observing meetings and transactions tem Gathering behavioral intelligence

Interview (Presence + Insight, DV 13):

tem Direct questioning of witnesses and suspects tem Reading body language and microexpressions tem Building rapport or applying pressure

Research (Wits + Investigation, DV 23):

tem Database searches and record checks tem Background investigations on persons of interest tem Crossreferencing information for patterns

Scene Examination (Wits + Perception, DV 14):

tem Physical evidence collection and analysis tem Crime scene reconstruction tem Pattern recognition in evidence placement

Infiltration (Wits + Subterfuge, DV 34):

tem Gaining access to restricted locations tem Undercover operations tem Social engineering and deception

Investigation Points: Spend 1 point to automatically succeed on any investigation action once per scene

Evidence Rating System:

tem **A+ Evidence:** Unimpeachable direct observation, clear documentation, multiple witnesses tem **A Evidence:** Strong solid documentation, reliable witness, clear chain of custody tem **B Evidence:** Good circumstantial but compelling, single reliable witness tem **C Evidence:** Fair circumstantial, questionable witness reliability tem **D Evidence:** Weak hearsay, speculation, compromised source tem **F Evidence:** Unreliable contradicted, obtained illegally, severely compromised

Evidence Degradation: Each day without followup reduces evidence quality by one grade

13.2 52Card Investigation Deck

sectionSpades (Crime/Incident)

tem 2. Stolen briefcase with confidential files tem 3. Hitandrun accident with no witnesses tem 4. Breakin at a highend art gallery tem 5. Corporate espionage discovered too late tem 6. Disappearance during a business trip tem 7. Blackmail attempt on a public figure tem 8. Forgery scheme unraveling publicly tem 9. Witness intimidation before trial tem 10. Evidence tampering in a murder case tem J. Corporate embezzlement scheme tem Q. Political scandal about to break tem K. Murder covered as suicide tem A. Case is actually an elaborate setup

sectionHearts (Person)

tem 2. Anxious secretary with hidden knowledge tem 3. Wealthy socialite with a dark past tem 4. Veteran security guard with PTSD tem 5. Ambitious assistant with

their own agenda tem 6. Retired detective turned private consultant tem 7. Tech genius with social anxiety tem 8. Politician's spouse with secrets tem 9. Former criminal trying to go straight tem 10. Journalist investigating corruption tem J. Disgraced lawyer seeking redemption tem Q. Corrupt police captain tem K. Crime boss's estranged child tem A. The person you trust most is involved

sectionClubs (Complication)

tem 2. Time pressure evidence disappears at midnight tem 3. Multiple suspects all have solid alibis tem 4. Key witness is afraid to talk tem 5. Crime scene was compromised tem 6. Someone is following your investigation tem 7. Crucial evidence is in a restricted area tem 8. Media attention making things difficult tem 9. Police are obstructing your work tem 10. You're being framed for a crime tem J. Someone is willing to kill to stop you tem Q. The case connects to your personal past tem K. Your client is lying to you tem A. Solving this case will destroy someone you care about

sectionDiamonds (Reward/Resolution)

tem 2. Substantial cash payment tem 3. Access to exclusive social circles tem 4. Professional reputation boost tem 5. Crucial evidence in another case tem 6. Protection from a dangerous person tem 7. Information that clears your name tem 8. A favor from a powerful figure tem 9. Resolution of a personal matter tem 10. Exposure of a major conspiracy tem J. Choice of eliminating or recruiting a foe tem Q. Control over a valuable resource tem K. Complete vindication of your methods tem A. The truth, no matter the personal cost

13.3 Quick Setup Procedure

tem Draw 3 cards (Spade, Heart, Club) tem Identify highest rank for Challenge Timer (25:4, 610:6, J/Q/K:8, A:10) tem Draw 1 Diamond for potential reward tem Start with 2 Investigation Points tem Draw 1 Vice card to determine potential temptations

13.4 Vice Timer System

Core Concept: The Vice Timer represents your character's ongoing struggle with personal demons that threaten to undermine their professional life and moral compass. It's a mechanical representation of the noir protagonist's fatal flaw.

Vice Timer Structure:

tem **4Segment Timer** : Visual tracker that increments during play tem **Increments:** +1 segment per scene (automatic unless prevented) tem **Prevention:** Spend 1 Boon to stop increment in that scene tem **Resolution:** Spend 2 Boons to clear 1 segment

13.5 16Card Vice Deck (Face Cards Only)

sectionHearts (Emotional Vice) Red:

tem **Jack:** "She's Trouble" Compulsive contact with toxic relationships tem **Queen:** "Lover's Betrayal" Romantic entanglements that compromise work tem **King:** "Obsessive Pursuit" Inability to let go of personal cases tem **Ace:** "Love Conquers All" Catastrophic sacrifice for unworthy causes

sectionSpades (Physical Vice) Black:

tem **Jack:** "Nightcap" Drinking affects performance and sleep tem **Queen:** "Hard Liquor" Regular substance abuse impacts health tem **King:** "Bottle Courage" Need substances for dangerous situations tem **Ace:** "Rock Bottom" Overdose, withdrawal, or violent episodes

sectionClubs (Professional Vice) Black:

tem **Jack:** "Bent Rules" Cutting corners attracts official scrutiny tem **Queen:** "Dirty Deals" Taking bribes or compromising ethics tem **King:** "Corrupt Core" Systematic abuse of professional position tem **Ace:** "Badge of Corruption" Authority weaponized for personal gain

sectionDiamonds (Psychological Vice) Red:

tem **Jack:** "Paranoid Tendencies" Seeing threats, alienating allies tem **Queen:** "Trust Issues" Inability to work effectively with others tem **King:** "Complete Isolation" No personal connections, vulnerable tem **Ace:** "Psychotic Break" Hallucinations, delusions, blackouts

13.6 Vice Timer States

1 Segment Temptation:

tem Generate 1 additional SB when rolling for actions related to this vice tem Minor roleplay reminders (character references the temptation)

2 Segments Habit:

tem Generate 2 additional SB when rolling for vicerelated actions tem 1 die penalty to rolls when resisting the vice tem Start scenes with 1 banked SB related to this vice

3 Segments Addiction:

tem Generate 3 additional SB when rolling for vicerelated actions tem 2 dice penalty to rolls when resisting or when deprived tem Must spend 1 Boon per session just to function normally tem Start scenes with 2 banked SB related to this vice

4 Segments Crisis:

tem Generate 4 additional SB when rolling for vicerelated actions tem 3 dice penalty to ALL rolls when deprived tem Cannot spend Boons for other benefits until crisis resolved tem Start scenes with 3 banked SB related to this vice

13.7 Vice Timer Management

Prevention (Ongoing):

tem **Cost:** 1 Boon per scene tem **Effect:** Prevent Vice Timer from incrementing

Mitigation (Active):

tem **Cost:** 2 Boons tem **Effect:** Clear 1 segment from Vice Timer

Escalation (When Full):

tem Draw new Vice card (same or different suit) tem Apply appropriate fallout based on card rank tem Reset timer based on new card (Jack=1, Queen=2, King=3, Ace=4)

13.8 Character Creation Integration

Starting Vice Timer Values:

tem **Jack Draw:** 1 segment tem **Queen Draw:** 2 segments tem **King Draw:** 3 segments tem **Ace Draw:** 4 segments (immediate crisis scene)

Multiple Vice Management:

tem Only one Vice Timer increments per scene (character's choice) tem Other vices generate 1 SB each per scene regardless tem Managing multiple vices requires proportionally more resources

13.9 Quick NPC System

The Femme Fatale:

tem **Archetype:** Dangerous woman with hidden agenda tem **Motivation:** Personal gain, revenge, or protection of secrets tem **Methods:** Manipulation, seduction, information control tem **Weakness:** Overconfidence, emotional vulnerability, overelaborate schemes tem **Red Flags:** Knows more than she should about the case; Appears at crucial moments; Has unexplained wealth or connections; Changes story when pressed tem **Potential Roles:** Client, witness, suspect, ally, or mastermind

The Corrupt Cop:

tem **Archetype:** Law enforcement officer on the take tem **Motivation:** Money, power, protection from own crimes tem **Methods:** Evidence tampering, witness intimidation, information brokering tem **Weakness:** Paranoia, need for control, pre-

dictable routines tem **Red Flags:** Always "conveniently" arrives late to crime scenes; Has unexplained income or expensive tastes; Knows details that weren't in official reports; Pressures investigation in specific directions tem **Potential Roles:** Investigator, suspect, obstruction, or reluctant informant

The Wealthy Businessman:

tem **Archetype:** Respectable figure with dark secrets tem **Motivation:** Protecting empire, eliminating threats, maintaining image tem **Methods:** Money, influence, legal intimidation, hired muscle tem **Weakness:** Public exposure, legal vulnerabilities, family concerns tem **Red Flags:** Everything seems legitimate on paper; Has connections in high places; Willing to spend large sums to "resolve" problems; Associates with unsavory characters discretely tem **Potential Roles:** Client, victim, suspect, employer, or case originator

The Broken Veteran:

tem **Archetype:** Former hero fallen on hard times tem **Motivation:** Survival, justice, redemption, or revenge tem **Methods:** Skills from past life, desperation, insider knowledge tem **Weakness:** Trauma, addiction, moral flexibility, isolation tem **Red Flags:** Has skills that don't match current circumstances; Knows too much about specific procedures or locations; Desperate for money but refuses certain jobs; Displays military or specialized training unconsciously tem **Potential Roles:** Informant, suspect, ally, victim, or tragic figure

The Informed Citizen:

tem **Archetype:** Ordinary person with crucial knowledge tem **Motivation:** Fear, conscience, revenge, or protection of loved ones tem **Methods:** Observation, accidental discovery, personal connection tem **Weakness:** Fear of consequences, incomplete information, personal bias tem **Red Flags:** Sees investigation but won't approach directly; Has information that doesn't fit official narrative; Behaves nervously around certain topics or people; Knows details that suggest personal involvement tem **Potential Roles:** Witness, reluctant informant, accidental victim, or key to breakthrough

13.10 Sample Quick Cases

The Missing Heirloom:

tem **Spade 7 (Crime):** A priceless family heirloom was stolen from a locked safe during a charity gala tem **Heart Q (Key Person):** The wealthy socialite whose family owns the item tem **Club 9 (Complication):** Multiple suspects had access, and the family has dark secrets they'd kill to protect tem **Diamond 6 (Reward):** Substantial finder's fee plus access to exclusive social circles tem **Clock:** 6 segments (media attention will ruin the family's reputation) tem **Quick Hook:** "Mrs. Black-

wood's emerald necklace disappeared sometime between 9 and 11 PM. The safe was locked, the room was secured, but the necklace is gone. The family is desperate to recover it before tomorrow's society pages." tem **Investigation Points:** Interview the butler, examine the safe for tampering, review security footage tem **Vice Timer Integration:** If investigating involves a romantic interest (Heart Q), players with Emotional Vice may face temptation. If family secrets involve corruption, Professional Vice players may be tempted.

The Blackmailer:

tem **Spade J (Crime):** Someone is threatening to expose a city councilman's affair unless paid tem **Heart 8 (Key Person):** The councilman's assistant who may know more than she's telling tem **Club K (Complication):** The blackmailer has connections in the police department tem **Diamond 10 (Reward):** The councilman will pay handsomely to end this quietly tem **Clock:** 8 segments (exposure will end the councilman's career and marriage) tem **Quick Hook:** "Councilman Harris has been receiving threatening letters demanding 50,000. *He's desperate but refuse to go to the police. Someone knows*

The Vanishing Witness:

tem **Spade A (Crime):** A key witness in a murder trial has disappeared the night before testimony tem **Heart 3 (Key Person):** The witness's roommate who claims to know nothing tem **Club 5 (Complication):** The witness owed money to dangerous people tem **Diamond 7 (Reward):** The DA's office will provide protection and a substantial reward tem **Clock:** 6 segments (the trial starts tomorrow and will collapse without the witness) tem **Quick Hook:** "Maria Santos was supposed to testify against the Torrino crime family tomorrow. She didn't show up for work this morning, and her apartment shows signs of a struggle. The prosecution's case will fall apart without her." tem **Investigation Points:** Search the apartment for clues, interview neighbors, check financial records tem **Vice Timer Integration:** Players with Psychological Vice may become paranoid about the danger. Those with Physical Vice may turn to substances under pressure.

This Modern Noir expansion provides GMs with flexible tools for running urban investigation campaigns while maintaining the mechanical elegance and player agency that defines Fate's Edge. Whether running a single session case or an extended noir campaign, these tools ensure that moral ambiguity and personal consequences remain central to the experience.

Remember that the best noir emerges from player investment in their characters' flaws and the urban environment around them. Use these mechanical tools to support narrative tension and character development, not replace them. The moral complexity of noir choices should feel meaningful and lasting.

In the shadows of the city, where neon lights cast long shadows and everyone has something to hide, the truth waits patiently. Will you find it? What will it cost you? Will you survive the consequences?